ST. BERNARD
HAPPENINGS

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State of the school

By Anabelle Howze

St. Bernard Preparatory School's new leadership structure took shape over several years of conversations with families and others connected to the school. Their feedback highlighted a need for stronger communication, while school leaders saw opportunities for employees to work more closely together.

"Our goal is to work as a team; the Lord himself had a team of apostles," said school President Fr. Paschal Pautler.

The restructuring introduces a vice president role dedicated to family engagement and public areas such as admissions and marketing. The headmaster will focus more directly on students, teachers and daily operations. According to Fr. Paschal, this division of responsibilities aims to provide stronger support for employees and foster better teamwork.

Fr. Paschal said the school also wants to build a closer partnership with families. In the Catholic tradition, parents are their children's primary educators, and St. Bernard works alongside them to support each student's growth.

These changes also support program growth. Fr. Paschal said leaders are working to strengthen academics and expand extracurricular opportunities. He cited the dorm proctor program as an example of growing student involvement in school life.

"This is not something we've done to them. It's something we do with them," he said.

Fr. Paschal stated that the school's long-term priorities are to develop students in body, mind and spirit. This requires strong academics and opportunities in the arts and athletics. He added that maintaining the campus and ensuring financial stability are essential to sustain these efforts for future generations.

The restructure is meant to place people in roles where their strengths can best serve the school. The president acknowledged that changes to a familiar institution can raise questions, and said the abbot and board of directors unan-

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Balancing the sacred and secular

Abbot Brendan John Seipel to lead St. Bernard Abbey

By Anabelle Howze and Tom Mayer

When the Right Reverend Brendan John Seipel was elected as St. Bernard Abbey's 11th abbot July 29, he knew his directive was clear: Seek first the kingdom of God. And it is that internal command, he said, that will guide him as he shepherds and balances the duties of an office responsible for both the sacred and secular needs of the monastic community in Cullman, Alabama.

"The role of the abbot is interesting because, unlike most leadership roles, the spiritual and temporal are so intertwined," Abbot Brendan said. "I think the abbots I've seen have done an excellent job of blending those two, and I hope to do that as well."

Nothing will immediately change, he said. In his first months as the monastery's leader, Abbot Brendan will meet with the monks and learn the office's daily work before deciding on any changes to established routines. After all, he said, the monastery's schedule is what keeps the community's shared purpose at the center of each day, a purpose that even the newest novice can state: "To seek Christ."

"That ultimately has to be the reasoning behind, in a certain sense, everything. Every decision, everything we do," Abbot Brendan said.

A RESPONSIBILITY ROOTED IN SERVICE

Abbot Brendan has served the St. Bernard community for 24 years in various roles, including guest master, director of the retreat center, director of the abbey farm, member of the senior council, subprior and prior. While these positions gave him administrative leadership experience, he noted that much of his preparation came from years of living in the community, observing and learning. His decade at the retreat center, however, stands out.

Serving as guest master and retreat center director showed that leadership is often expressed as service, the abbot said. While caring for guests required some administrative skills, being attentive to others' needs mattered even more.

"That experience taught me what it means to serve," he said. "If you're a guest master or retreat center director, that is pure service."

He brings the same understanding to his role as abbot.

Abbot Brendan said that providing stability, along with ensuring that monks have the resources necessary to live their vocation, are among his most important responsibilities. Citing the Rule of St. Benedict, he stated that an abbot is called to seek the welfare of the monks rather than his own benefit.

Above all, his hopes to sup-

See **ABBOT,** 2



Photo by Tom Mayer

Abbot Brendan John Seipel is at work in his office soon after his announcement as St. Bernard Abbey's 11th abbot.



The monks of St. Bernard Abbey and the Diocese of Birmingham welcome Abbot Brendan John Seipel as the Cullman, Alabama, monastery's new abbot.

St. Bernard seeks US 278 solution

By Tom Mayer

As state transportation officials develop plans to widen U.S. 278 near St. Bernard Preparatory School, St. Bernard monks, staff and families are pressing for a traffic signal at the campus entrance, saying heavier traffic makes entering and leaving the property increasingly difficult and potentially dangerous.

Father Paschal Pautler, school president, said the school wants a signal at St. Bernard Drive to provide a controlled way for motorists to cross traffic and turn onto the highway. He worries that the planned road improvements, without a signal, will leave drivers facing a worse problem even after construction.

"The biggest problem is that the traffic is so tight both ways on 278; it's hard to exit the campus," Fr. Paschal said.

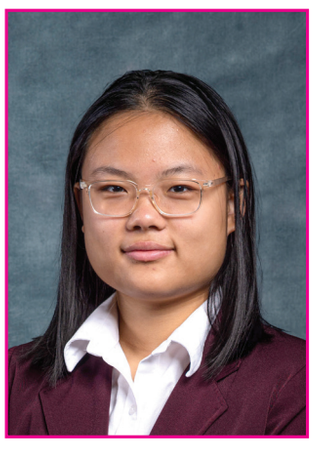
The Alabama Department of

See **HIGHWAY,** 3



A current rendering of US 278 widening shows no traffic light at the St. Bernard intersection.

Miles from home, memories for a lifetime



Yulissa Wang

By Anabelle Howze

When Yulissa Wang first came to St. Bernard Preparatory School from China, she was surprised that so many students already knew her name. On her first day, classmates she had never met asked how she was doing.

It took Yulissa a while to feel comfortable. She was still learning English, so talking with others was sometimes hard. By spring break of her freshman year, she had become friends with a classmate named Sage. Four years later, they are still friends.

Living in the dorms was new for Yulissa. As an only child, she had never shared a home with other students. Now, she thinks of the other girls in the dorm as sisters. She also remembers a kind teacher from her first day of classes. When the teacher saw she was having trouble keeping up, she shared that she was new to St. Bernard, too and suggested they learn about the school together.

Over time, Yulissa found more ways to get involved at school. She runs cross-country and likes archery. Through the art club, she has helped younger kids with art projects. She also enjoys St. Bernard's festivals, especially the food.

Some of her favorite memories are from her first days at school. Once, while talking with another student, she started speaking Chinese because she didn't know the English words yet. Now, she laughs about it. She also remembers being confused when she was put on both teams for her first Blue and White Day, but played for both anyway. Considering college, Yulissa is interested in studying health science. She has begun looking at schools in Alabama, though her plans are still taking shape.

Yulissa says she will miss the people at St. Bernard and the campus she has grown to love. She values the personal attention she received from St. Bernard's teachers and the friendships that made a place far from home feel like home.

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New A.D. brings winning experience

By Tom Mayer

At St. Bernard Preparatory School, new athletic director Daniel Howard is looking at the school's sports program with the enthusiasm of someone who has spent most of his life around athletics.

For Howard, sports have been part of the picture for as long as he can remember.

"I'm just a sports fanatic," he said. "Just all things sports."

Growing up in Tennessee, Howard played baseball, football and basketball and swam in high school. But his playing career changed during his junior year when he was diagnosed with stage three melanoma and became a St. Jude patient in Memphis.

He underwent four surgeries on his head and neck and about 13 months of chemotherapy. The treatment affected his eyesight and larynx, and he still cannot yell loudly.

Unable to continue competing at the level he once had, Howard found another way to remain involved in sports.

"I always wanted to still be in the sports world," he said.

He earned bachelor's degrees in business and sports management and later earned a master's degree in sports management. He eventually played three years of semiprofessional football for the Pensacola Wolf Pack in Florida.

It was in Pensacola that Howard became involved with flag football, first as a player and then as a coach. He also served as a youth pastor, coaching a flag football team made up of young people from his church.

After getting married and having children, Howard moved back north and continued coaching his sons in baseball, football and basketball through the park and middle school systems.

His professional path eventually led him to Wallace State, where he first helped with baseball and later with cross country. He also spent three years as the college's athletics coordinator, a position he describes as essentially being the system's athletic director.



Photo by Tom Mayer

St. Bernard Prep Athletic Director Daniel Howard.

Then came flag football.

Wallace State introduced the sport last year, and Howard became its coach. He helped recruit players and spent considerable time on the road looking for athletes.

The result was a 26-0 season, a conference championship and Howard being named coach of the year. The team also defeated teams from Division I schools in tournament play and finished No. 19 in the nation in a ranking that included four-year schools.

Now Howard is trying to bring that experience to St. Bernard while continuing to coach part-time for Wallace State's flag football team. Wallace State is 8-0 this season, he said.

At St. Bernard, one of his immediate goals is to build a flag football program.

The sport has already generated interest among students, Howard said, and students have been learning some of the fundamentals during physical education classes. Both boys and girls participate in PE flag football.

"I think it's coming," Howard said of the possibility of boys' high school flag football eventually becoming more widely established.

For now, Alabama high school flag football is a girls' sport, and Howard is working with the Alabama High School Athletic Association in bringing the sport to St. Bernard. He said the school can begin building a team before it becomes a varsity sport.

Howard sees flag football as a natural fit for St. Bernard, particularly because the school does not have a traditional football team.

But flag football is only one piece of his plans.

Because St. Bernard is a smaller school, Howard said he wants to concentrate on sports that can work with the student population, including individual and smaller-team sports.

Bowling is starting back this year. Tennis is also returning, and with a new coach. Archery is another part of the program, and Howard is becoming NASP certified so he can help with it. He also praised the new basketball coaching staff.

"We're slowly growing," Howard said of the school.

As enrollment grows, he said, the goal will be to have enough athletes for varsity, junior varsity and middle school teams in more sports.

Howard also sees winning as part of the growth strategy for SBP athletics.

"When you start winning as a team," he said, students become more interested and want to be part of it.

But Howard is quick to point out that St. Bernard athletes face a challenge that differs from what he has encountered at other schools: academics come first.

Students at St. Bernard have a rigorous academic workload, and many athletes participate in multiple sports.

"It's the first school I've been to where people are asking if they can not play sports," he said, because they need to study.

So far, Howard said, the students have handled the demands well.

The athletic director is also looking beyond teams and schedules to the physical facilities.

He is beginning with the basketball arena and hopes to upgrade the weight room, add a score table and make better use of televisions in the gym. He also wants to develop advertising opportunities that could help generate money for the athletic program.

Outside, Howard has plans for the tennis courts, and he wants to add outdoor basketball courts and possibly one or two pickleball courts.

Indoor pickleball is also in the works.

Howard discovered pickleball while living in Florida and quickly became a fan of the sport, particularly because people of different ages can play it. He hopes it eventually can become something that brings students, staff and even members of the St. Bernard community together.

He would like to see more events that involve the broader school community, including staff-student games, alumni activities and pep rallies.

Another project would connect the present athletic program with St. Bernard's history.

Howard wants to decorate a wall near the gym with photographs and other reminders of the school's athletic history, reaching back through the years of St. Bernard Prep and the college.

He envisions students walking down the hall and gaining an understanding of St. Bernard sports history dating to 1891.

For Howard, though, building an athletic program is about more than wins, facilities or new sports.

It is about getting students excited about athletics.

He describes himself as quiet and reserved away from sports. But put him around athletics and he becomes, in his words, "like a cheerleader out there."

The students notice that enthusiasm, he said.

"They see that I care," Howard said.

And that may be the starting point for the program he hopes to build at St. Bernard.

There is plenty of work ahead. Howard has already begun identifying improvements that need to be made, from facilities and fundraising to recruiting and adding sports.

But he said he has been impressed by the administration and is looking forward to seeing what can be accomplished during a full year at St. Bernard.

"I'm just looking forward to a good year," he said.

Howard is also bringing a family of his own into that work. He has three sons — 14-year-old twins and a 5-year-old — and describes life with them as a nonstop rotation of sports and activities.

For a new athletic director whose own path through sports began as a child, that sounds fitting.

And at St. Bernard, Howard is ready to see where the next season takes him.



Photo by Tom Mayer

St. Bernard Prep Athletic Director Daniel Howard, right, works with basketball coach Jimmy Fletcher.

ABBOT

FROM PAGE 1

port the monks in their vocation extend to the wider responsibilities that accompany the office. "To the extent that you lead, you serve," he said. "It's really a servant's role in many, many ways."

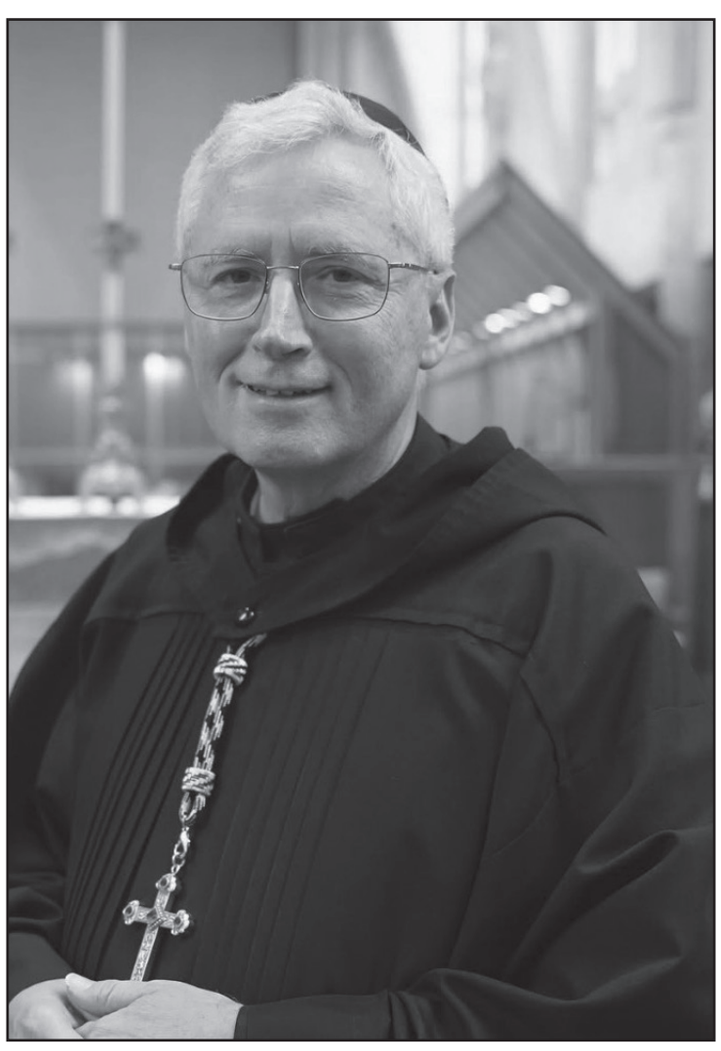
AN UNUSUAL PATH TO THE ABBACY

Abbot Brendan's election represents a notable moment in the history of St. Bernard — and much of the Roman Catholic world. He was elected abbot before he was ordained a priest, a situation permitted by a 2022 rescript issued by Pope Francis. This directive allows non-ordained members of clerical religious institutes to serve as major superiors with approval from the Dicastery for Institutes of Consecrated Life.

His election and Vatican approval, Abbot Brendan noted, was a humbling experience.

Although the offices of abbot and priest are distinct, he noted that their roles can become closely intertwined, especially when an abbot serves as the spiritual father of a monastic community. Already assuming the role of abbot, which became effective upon his election, and ahead of his tentative ordination date next year, Abbot Brendan looks forward to one day serving the sacramental needs of the community as a priest by celebrating Mass, anointing the sick and presiding at funerals.

These unusual circumstances, he said, have deepened his appreciation for the historical significance of his election. Abbot Brendan follows Abbot Isaac Murphy, elected abbot of Saint Anselm Abbey in Manchester, New Hampshire, in 2024, as one of the first non-ordained



Abbot Brendan John Seipel

Benedictine abbots in modern American history. While exceptional in recent centuries, this is not without precedent in the Church's long monastic tradition. Saint Benedict is generally believed not to have been a priest, and in the early centuries of Benedictine monasticism, priestly ordination was not a requirement for serving as abbot.

"If I mess this up, they won't do it again for a long time," he said with a laugh, describing the responsibility he feels for his election.

Recalling the day he learned he would be St. Bernard Abbey's monastic leader, Abbot Brendan speaks less about plans for his tenure than about serving the community's needs. He wanted to accept the role "one step at a time," staying available to the community and doing the work of God.

That simple acceptance characterizes the monk who has spent a life in service. During the election period, a visiting monk assisting with the process asked then-Prior Brendan what plans and goals he had for leading the abbey. When he said he had none, the surprised monk said, "You should be elected abbot." Brendan took the exchange as a reminder that an abbot must leave room for God to act, rather than enter the office with a personal agenda.

ABBEY AND SCHOOL, GROWING TOGETHER

Although Abbot Brendan does not articulate a predetermined agenda for his tenure, he acknowledges several areas of growth at St. Bernard. One is the future of St. Bernard Preparatory School.

He identified establishing the school's budgetary stability as a key priority, alongside preserving strong academics and athletics. He also emphasized the ongoing need to provide a safe environment for every student, saying parents and prospective families should be able to trust that their children will be safe at St. Bernard.

However, he cautioned that the school and monastery should not be regarded as separate components of St. Bernard's future.

"Our school and the abbey are so deeply connected, I don't think either can thrive without the other," he said.

As an example, he noted that increasing the number of monks teaching at the school can strengthen the institution, and our students bring a certain vibrancy and vitality to the campus.

Within the monastery, he views ongoing formation of current monks and the recruitment of new vocations as essential to strengthening the community for the future. Nevertheless, he resists presenting these priorities as a personal platform. He explained that electing an abbot is not like electing a political leader who enters office with a campaign platform. Instead, his responsibility is to listen, respond and care for what has been entrusted to him.

A PASSING GUEST

Although Abbot Brendan, as the abbey's 11th abbot, does not articulate a sweeping vision for his service, he did say that he hopes to leave St. Bernard in as good or better condition than he found it. He recalled a line from Psalm 39 that has taken on particular meaning for him: "In your house I am a passing guest, O Lord."

For Abbot Brendan, that stewardship means caring for the monks and monastery while helping the school thrive. He sees that work as part of something larger than any one leader's tenure. "Ultimately, it's God's enterprise," he said. "Each person is, and the whole St. Bernard is, ultimately in God's hands."

Years ago, the late Brother Joseph Weiss shared an observation with him that Abbot Brendan has carried ever since. "Every place I look at St. Bernard, I see opportunity," he was told.

After more than two decades in the monastery, and now entrusted with leading it, Abbot Brendan said he still sees the same thing.

"Pretty much every place you look," he said, "you can see potential and opportunity."

ABBOTS OF ST. BERNARD ABBEY

1. Benedict Menges, O.S.B. — 1891—1904
2. Bernard Menges, O.S.B. — 1904—1933
3. Ambrose Reger, O.S.B. — 1933—1938
4. Boniface Seng, O.S.B. (first American-born SBA abbot) — 1939—1952
5. Bede Luibel, O.S.B. — 1952—1964
6. Gregory Roettger, O.S.B. — 1967—1972
7. Hilary Dreaper, O.S.B. — 1972—1987
8. Victor Clark, O.S.B. — 1987—1995
9. Cletus Meagher, O.S.B. — 1995—2019
10. Marcus Voss, O.S.B. — July 2019—October 2025
11. Brendan Seipel, O.S.B. — July 29, 2026—present

STATE

FROM PAGE 1

imously supported the plan, including the addition of a vice president role.

Having spent more than over half his life at St. Bernard — beginning as a student — Fr. Paschal expressed optimism about the opportunity to advance the school's mission through these changes.

The school's mission remains grounded in the Benedictine community that established the monastery in 1891. Fr. Paschal said the monks' vision of a community shaped by work, prayer and service continues to guide the school as it adapts over time.

"Our point was ultimately to be a city on a hill," he said, "a witness of God's love and presence in the world."

Start the season with Christmas at the Grotto

By Anabelle Howze

Christmas lights offer a new perspective on Ave Maria Grotto, even for longtime visitors. Illuminated after dark, Brother Joseph Zoettl's miniature creations provide a peaceful setting to reflect on the meaning of Christmas.

Christmas at the Grotto is back for its eighth year in November. Director Roger Steele said the event started as a trial in 2019, when only half the park was open at night. With little time to get ready, the first display used mostly spotlights and a small set of lights.

Since then, it has become a holiday tradition for families and helps support the monastery. The event now lasts more than 20 nights, with live music and visits from Santa Claus on some evenings. Horse-drawn wagon rides are another special activity.

This year's event begins Nov. 19 and runs on select dates through Dec. 27. You can find the full schedule, admission prices and special activities in the pinned event on Ave Maria Grotto's Facebook page and at avemariagrotto.com.

Steele said the Grotto adds to Cullman's Christmas attractions by giving people a peaceful place to reflect on Christ's birth. Visitors walk through the lit-up grounds, where Nativity displays help keep that meaning at the heart of the event.

"The spiritual, the peaceful aspect of what Christmas is all about, I think, is on full display here," Steele said.

The displays change every year, so returning visitors always have something new to see. This season, Steele hopes to reopen an old trail built by Brother Joseph, letting guests walk through a wooded part of the Grotto. They plan to add Nativity scenes along the path, but preparations are still in progress.

For some families, visiting has become a tradition they enjoy several times each season. Steele said the event also brings guests from outside the area, including people who have come from Mobile just to see the lights.

He encourages anyone who has only seen the Grotto during the day to come back for an evening visit.

"If you've seen it during the day, seeing it at night is a completely different experience," he said.



The Grotto is decorated with Christmas lights for last year's Christmas at the Grotto celebration.

Club updates

By Anabelle Howze

At St. Bernard Preparatory School, Saints Period gives students time to explore interests outside the classroom through activities that support their academic, spiritual and personal growth.

Fr. Dominic Lee's chess club is all about enjoying the game. Students play in a relaxed setting and learn to appreciate the skill it takes. Guy Smith also runs a cards club.

Students curious about the ancient world can join Br. Damien's Latin club, where they explore Roman history and culture. Games introduce new topics and help build on what students learn in Latin class, giving them a better sense of the people who spoke the language.

In Mr. James Griffin's Don Bosco Club, students gather for casual chats that give them space to reflect on their faith. Inspired by St. John Bosco's historic ministry with youth, the club is entirely focused on helping students grow spiritually.

Students use Mrs. Ashley Hasenbein's study hall to knock out daily assignments or wrap up their college applications. According to Mrs. Hasenbein, having this built-in time during the day takes the pressure off their evenings and keeps them on top of their schoolwork.

Dr. Craig Mann leads the Community Service Team, which has already started helping out. Students cleaned dining areas and helped set up the food tent for Bernard Blues & BBQ. After the festival, they cleaned up and packed away signs.

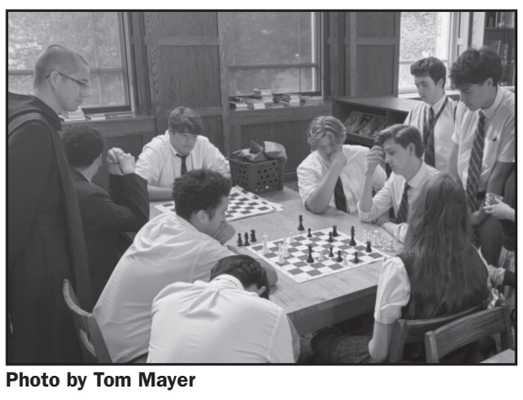


Photo by Tom Mayer

Chess Club.

"The St. Bernard Community Service Team was founded to do exactly as our name implies: to serve," Mann said.

The team plans to help Curt's Closet with its "Curt's Christmas" program, which provides Christmas gifts and essentials to local children and families in need. In the spring, members hope to visit Fort Campbell, Kentucky, again with the USO, to thank soldiers. Local service projects will give more chances to help during the year.

Other Saints Period options include Mrs. Amber Watts' art club, archery with Ms. Elicia Fallin, Garden Club with Mrs. Connie Briehn and the GLAD club led by Mrs. Valjean Cox.

These activities let students try things they enjoy and get more involved in the St. Bernard community.

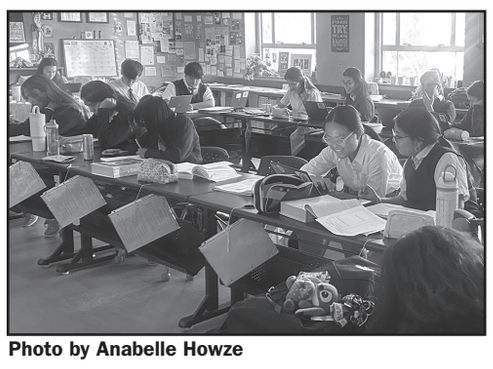


Photo by Anabelle Howze

Hasenbein Study Hall.



Photo by Craig Mann

Community Service Club.

HIGHWAY

FROM PAGE 1

Transportation's project calls for widening U.S. 278 from Fourth Avenue in Cullman toward East Point to five lanes, with two through lanes in each direction and a center turn lane. The project also includes replacing the bridge over Eightmile Creek with a wider structure to accommodate the additional lanes.

Fr. Paschal said he was disappointed to learn that the proposed design included no traffic signal at the St. Bernard entrance, despite initial graphics seeming to indicate one.

In addition to St. Bernard Preparatory School, St. Bernard Abbey also operates a busy retreat center and nationally recognized pilgrimage site, Ave Maria Grotto, on the same property. The Grotto is also inscribed on the National Register of Historic Places, the official list of the Nation's historic places worthy of preservation. After encouraging community members to submit comments, Fr. Paschal said he was told the department had reviewed traffic data and determined the number of reported accidents did not warrant a signal.

"It's disappointing," Fr. Paschal said, "that past accidents at a two-lane intersection would be used to determine the safety of a newly designed five-lane intersection."

The concern is especially acute during morning and afternoon traffic, when vehicles back up on U.S. 278 and drivers leaving the school can feel pressured to pull into small gaps. Fr. Paschal said student drivers may be particularly susceptible to that pressure.

"When they look in their rearview mirror and see 20 cars behind them, they feel pressure to go," he said. "And they're more inclined to try and chance it."

Fr. Paschal also argued that a signal would not necessarily worsen congestion. He said motorists already stop voluntarily to let school traffic enter the highway, creating informal breaks in the flow of traffic.

"Instead of having to rely on catching somebody's eye and then them stopping, it's a safer way for them," he said.

Fr. Paschal said he is grateful to continue talks with Alabama Department of Transportation officials and looks forward to a solution that addresses the safety of the many people — monks, students, parents, visitors, staff — entering and leaving the campus.

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From lawman to farmer, musician and mentor, SRO finds a home



SRO Billy Kyle James



Photo by Tom Mayer

St. Bernard Preparatory School SRO Billy Kyle James gets some helping hands from a few of the students he jokes with during a lunch break Sept. 18, on the school campus.

By Tom Mayer

When Officer Billy Kyle James first came to St. Bernard Preparatory School, he wasn't sure he would stay.

He had spent years in law enforcement, including work as a road deputy, jail officer, probation and parole officer and supervisor. He had also already served as a school resource officer.

But being an SRO at a Catholic boarding school wasn't simply a matter of wearing a badge and making sure the campus was secure. There were students to meet. Teachers to get to know. Parents, maintenance workers, cooks and monks to become familiar with.

And, most importantly, there were relationships to build.

"The first year I was here, I was ready to quit," James said.

It wasn't because he didn't take the job seriously. Quite the opposite. But when students first saw him, many avoided him.

"And in my mind, I'm playing it out, OK, are they thinking I'm here to get them, catch them doing something?" he said. "And that was not it."

Over time, that changed. Today, James says he feels "part of the family now instead of an outcast."

That transformation may be the best way to understand James and the way he approaches his job at St. Bernard. His number one responsibility, he said, is simple.

"I'm here to make sure kids go home."

A CAREER THAT FOUND ITS WAY TO ST. BERNARD

James began his law enforcement career in 1986 as a reserve deputy in Cullman County. After six years, he was hired full time by the Sheriff's Department, where he spent 13 years working in several capacities.

He later worked in community corrections and then as a school resource officer before accepting a position with the state as a probation and parole officer in 2006.

He spent two years in Jefferson County and then transferred to Winston County, where he worked for about 10 years, including several years as a supervisor.

After retiring from the state, James returned to school resource work. Eventually, an opening at St. Bernard came through former Cullman Chief of Police Kenny Culpepper.

James had told Culpepper that he was interested in an SRO position. Culpepper told him that there were currently no open positions.

"I told him to keep my name in," James said.

The next morning, Culpepper called.

"We've got a position at St. Bernard," James recalled him saying.

The arrangement allowed James to work for both the city and St. Bernard, and it also worked with his state retirement.

That was in 2022. James has been at St. Bernard ever since, sharing the weekly workload with the officer who put him at St. Bernard in the first place, Culpepper.

LEARNING TO TRUST— AND BE TRUSTED

James' first year at the school taught him something he hadn't fully anticipated. A school resource officer can't simply walk onto a campus and expect students to trust him because he is a police officer.

That trust has to be earned. At St. Bernard, two students helped get that process started.

One was a student named Peter, who later joined the Marine Corps. The other was Jack, a student James remembers as being particularly quiet.

James likes to joke with people, but he quickly learned that students didn't always know when he was joking.

"Whenever I would try to joke with a student, they always took me serious," he said.

With Jack, however, something changed after one of James' jokes.

Later, during a pep rally, Jack walked over to where James was sitting by himself and started a conversation with him.

Afterward, James encountered Jack's mother in the parking lot.

"She told me, 'If Jack did that to you, that means he's got confidence in you, because he doesn't do that to just anybody,'" James said.

That mattered. So did the students who came after him.

There was Emily, a student who joked with James about having him sing the National Anthem at graduation. There were students he gave nicknames to. There were students who waved when they saw him.

Gradually, more students started talking to him.

For James, those small interactions became something much larger.

Every year at graduation, he gives a silver dollar to several seniors he has developed relationships with, getting their parents' approval first. He also includes a card with a Bible verse reminding them to trust in the Lord.

One year, he gave out seven, and today, he keeps photographs of some of his favorite graduating classes.

He also still has a card and gift card given to him by students who interviewed him for the school newspaper.

"I still got the little gift card they gave me," he said. "I never cashed it."

But the accompanying message meant so much to him that, he said, it nearly brought him to tears.

"It's all about relationships," James said.

THE SERIOUS SIDE OF THE BADGE

The humor and relationships don't diminish the seriousness with which James views his responsibility. School safety is always on his mind, and particularly the possibility of a school shooting.

He makes a point of being visible around campus. He watches entrances and different areas of the school, because he believes an officer's presence can be an important deterrent.

He also pays attention to what he calls "false security." Book bags left unattended, for example, concern him because of the possibility that something could be placed inside them. He believes classroom doors should remain closed and that students need to be trained to respond appropriately during an emergency.

James participates in training that prepares officers to respond to an active shooter. He has been through exercises where officers work as a team to clear buildings while dealing with the realities of an active-shooter scenario.

But his concern isn't limited to what he would do as an officer.

He wants students to understand what they should do, too.

"Kids need to be trained on what to do in that situation," he said.

His reason for taking that responsibility so personally is straightforward.

"I treat every one of these kids like they're mine," he said. "If that was my daughter here, I would treat her the same as I do with these kids, because these kids all have a special place in my heart."

MAKING FRIENDS ACROSS CAMPUS

The relationships James has built aren't limited to students.

"I've made some good friends," he said of the faculty. "But I'm not the type of person that sticks with just faculty."

He makes friends with the maintenance workers. He makes friends with the cooks.

"I always say," James said, "when you're a resource officer, first thing you do is make friends with the cooks. Because they're the ones cooking your food, and they will take care of you."

At St. Bernard, making friends also means getting to know the monks. That has produced some memorable moments.

During his first year, James was outside doing traffic duty when someone dressed in black and wearing a hoodie emerged from the woods.

He didn't know the Benedictine monks yet, who are clothed in black habits with hoods.

"So, I addressed the situation," he said. "I found out it was a monk."

Now, he has learned which monks he can joke with and which ones he should approach a little differently.

He calls many of them "brother," partly because remembering names isn't as easy as it used to be. He has learned that the priests should be addressed as fathers.

He also knows that one particular priest, St. Bernard Preparatory School president Fr. Paschal Pautler, has a sense of humor.

One day at a school Mass, James' cellphone went off during Fr. Paschal's homily.

James quickly left the vestibule, hoping nobody had heard it.

Fr. Paschal later told him he thought it was funny.

"I'm glad it was you and not a student," he told James — especially since students are not allowed to use cell phones during school hours.

That's another relationship James has come to appreciate.

A FARMER, MUSICIAN AND ARTIST

Away from the school, James has plenty to keep him busy.

He owns a cattle farm in Cullman County with about 30 to 35 head of cattle. He spends much of the summer working in hay fields, and he and Culpepper work around that schedule when necessary.

He bought the farm after retiring from the state, using money he had been owed for vacation days to purchase cattle, tractors and other equipment.

"I love doing things, especially if it's got a form of art," he said.

That philosophy shows up in unexpected places.

James learned to play guitar as a youngster, teaching himself from chords his father drew out for him. He later learned to play piano after a friend showed him some things.

He still plays at St. Bernard when he gets the opportunity for a quick break.

He also dabbles in oil painting. As a student at Wallace State Community College, he took an art class and eventually painted a portrait of his grandfather.

"It was just like him," James said. "I was happy."

He has restored a 1966 Chevrolet truck, cutting and installing its wooden bed himself, painted parts of his own truck and tackled automobile repairs after watching instructional videos.

"If I watch it on YouTube and I realize I can't fix it, I don't even tackle it. I'll pay somebody," he said. "But nine times out of 10, I will ... fix it myself."

THE ROAD THAT STARTED IN THIRD GRADE

In some ways, James' career began when he was a third-grader and a police officer visited his school.

"I thought it was so cool, and I thought, I'd like to do that," he said.

Years later, after spending eight years out of school and working jobs that paid little, James decided to change direction.

He drove to Wallace State and walked inside.

"I said, 'Tell me how to sign up,'" he recalled.

He did.

Two years later, he graduated from Wallace. He went on to Athens State University and earned an elementary teaching certificate. He was also pursuing a master's degree at the University of Alabama before job responsibilities prevented him from completing it.

The path eventually brought him back to law enforcement, then to school resource work, and finally to St. Bernard.

There is a consistency to the way James describes all of it: If something interests him, he gives it a try.

Law enforcement. Farming. Guitar. Piano. Painting. Restoring a truck. Fixing things.

And now, being part of a school community — and part of a new family. James became a grandfather in January, an experience he says has changed his life.

Today, he also enjoys following hockey and has made friendships through the sport, including trips to watch games.

But on school days, his focus remains the same. He wants to be there.

He tries not to leave campus unless he has to. When he does have to be away, arrangements are made so the school remains covered, including close patrols by other officers when neither school resource officer can be present.

Because for James, being an SRO isn't simply about being available when something goes wrong.

It is about being known before something goes wrong.

It is about a student feeling comfortable enough to walk over and start a conversation.

It is about a parent knowing who is watching over the campus.

It is about a cook, maintenance worker, teacher or monk knowing the officer who is there every day.

And it is about trust.

"That's the important part of the job," James said. "Developing that trust. Keeping kids and faculty safe. That's my top priority."



Photo by Tom Mayer

Beyond protecting students on campus, St. Bernard Preparatory School SRO Billy Kyle James takes a break to entertain staff in the Admissions Building.

Bernard Blues & BBQ

Bernard Blues and BBQ brought people together on September 12-13 with live blues music, tasty barbecue and a welcoming atmosphere. Guests enjoyed great food and entertainment while celebrating the local community and browsing a beautiful artisan craft show. It was a great chance for everyone to meet up, connect and have fun.

Photos by Anabelle Howze























